

King Leopold  
Berlin Conference  
Race to Africa

The benefits of Colonisation in Africa were raw materials like ivory, new markets, and land. King Leopold of Belgium, who ruled a nation too small for his liking, desired expansion and power. Convincing Europe that his actions toward Africa were “humanitarian” works was a key reason for his success in developing a colony in the Congo. Under Leopold’s reign of the Congo, the population dropped from around 1.5 to 13 million which is referred to as the Congolese Genocide. Belgium implemented a forced labor system used by other European Countries in Africa otherwise known as slavery. In 1884, The Berlin Conference was called to discuss European colonization in Africa. The Conference, arranged by the Chancellor of Germany, Otto Von Bismark, at the request of King Leopold II of Belgium, concluded with the establishment of the General Act. The General Act of Berlin addressed many issues involving slavery but more importantly, provided a political framework for the partition of Africa.

King Leopold believed that European countries should have sovereign rule over their colonies. Leopold sent many explorers to explore Africa over the course of 20 years and report back. Explorers such as Henry Stanley found the Congo. After the Berlin Conference, Belgium received the vast territory of the Congo Free State. King Leopold believed that Africans were inferior to Europeans and that they should not have representation in the decision-making of African territory. One reason for his position is the economic benefits including the extraction of rubber and ivory. King Leopold argues that if nations like Britain and France have colonies then there is no reason Belgium could not make use of Africa’s wealth as well.

King Leopold offers multiple solutions to the problems posed by the colonization of Africa. The problems include slavery and persecution, territorial claims, and the extraction of raw materials. Leopold will help solve these problems alongside the other delegates as long as his interests are being met. For example, Belgium will have a quota for the quantity of raw materials that need to be extracted, if these quotas are met, either through trade or extraction, Belgium is open to ending slavery and forced labor. For too long, major European countries have been profiting off the same lands they prevent other countries from colonizing, now, Leopold is not going to allow other countries to dictate his sovereignty. Leopold would like to establish an economic and territorial agreement with other countries for raw materials and expansion. Not only will this profit both countries, it will greatly increase their power.

## **Sources:**

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